China’s oil demand has peaked

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【要点】

・中国の石油需要はピークを迎え、国内需要の弱さと電動車の急速な普及により、今後の回復は限定的となる見通しである。

・北京は市場効率性よりエネルギー安全保障を優先し、中央集約的な在庫管理と原油調達源の多角化を進め、消費者を高原油価格から保護する方針である。

・中国は石油需要が高い時期を買い控えるため、在庫を戦略的に活用しており、精製業者の在庫補充期間を延長することで高値での購入を回避している。

・中国の石油需要ピークは世界全体の消費プラトーを加速させ、最近数十年間で世界の新規石油需要増加を牽引してきた中国の影響が大きく低下する。

【メール原文】

China’s oil demand has peaked. An end to the Iran war would not likely restore Chinese demand to its pre-war trajectory (see: China will not return to

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Short-term trajectory:
Long-term trajectory:

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Weak domestic demand, rapid electrification, and feedstock substitution will limit the extent of any oil demand recovery.
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Beijing will prioritize energy security over market efficiency through centralized inventory management and diversified crude sourcing, while shielding consumers from higher crude costs by requiring producers to absorb them.
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Refined-product export controls will remain an ongoing risk, driven by domestic concerns, though new refining capacity could ease constraints over time.

China’s oil demand has peaked. An end to the Iran war would not likely restore Chinese demand to its pre-war trajectory (see: China will not return to pre-Covid oil demand growth in 2024 or after , 21 February 2024). Weak domestic activity and rapid electrification will cap middle distillate demand, while Beijing’s growing emphasis on energy security will create a structural ceiling on oil consumption. Infrastructure investment recorded its biggest decline in six years in the third quarter, while electric

vehicles displaced roughly 6% of crude imports in the first half of this year. Looking forward, coal-based chemicals have the potential to replace some oil feedstocks at roughly one-third lower cost (see: New policies will benefit coal-to-chemicals and green molecules , 25 June 2026). Other refined products have largely been destined for export.

China's peak oil demand will hasten a global plateau in consumption. China has been by far the biggest single driver of new oil demand growth in recent decades, and other growth markets such as South and Southeast Asia can't fully replace this growth, especially since Beijing is increasingly exporting its energy transition (see: India's growing economy cannot offset the weakening global oil demand outlook , 17 October 2023).

Beijing is using inventories to avoid buying expensive oil. At the beginning of the war, Chinese oil companies held ample commercial stockpiles, allowing them to refrain from buying expensive oil. As a result, crude imports fell to a decade low in June without explicit government guidance. Since April, Beijing has centralized crude inventory management and extended the mandatory windows within which refiners must replenish their required stockpiles from 1-2 months to 3-5 months, giving the companies more time to avoid buying at high spot prices. By centralizing control over inventory drawdowns and replenishment timing, Beijing ensures it can maintain domestic supply continuity during periods of external disruption without being forced into the market at unfavorable prices—a key pillar of its broader energy security strategy. Imports recovered somewhat in the third quarter but remained well below pre-war levels. Companies have drawn from their own inventories, while the government-held Strategic Petroleum Reserve—equivalent to 120 days of crude imports—remains untouched. Eurasia Group industry contacts expect state oil companies to add 400,000 barrels per day to their reserves between November and April.

Geopolitics is reshaping China's crude supply. Russian crude reached a record 30% of Chinese imports in August, exceeding China's implicit 20% ceiling on reliance on a single supplier, while Iranian shipments roughly halved after US sanctions in July. Canadian heavy sour crude, well-suited to Shandong's refineries, is filling part of the gap. Chinese buyers have already secured 20 cargoes of Canadian heavy sour crude for November and December, about one-third more than in 2025. China has received 73% of Canada's Trans Mountain Expansion crude exports since 2024. US refinery closures and increased Venezuelan shipments to the US are freeing up more Canadian barrels for China. Venezuela has not yet resumed its role as a major supplier to China because Washington has not approved oil-for-debt transactions.

Beijing will prioritize domestic fuel supply over export margins. In the second quarter, the state oil companies were required to cut throughput and refined product exports under official guidance to protect domestic supply. The National Development and Reform Commission (NDRC) adjusts domestic fuel prices every two weeks, and, in principle, stops raising prices when crude exceeds $130 per barrel. Chinese industrial producers have absorbed most of the higher input costs with little passed through to downstream consumers. The producers' price index and consumer price index have long been disconnected in China. Overcapacity and price-sensitive households constrain firms' ability to raise prices without losing market share.

China's refined-product export controls will remain an ongoing risk while Iran disruptions persist. Beijing relaxed export restrictions in July but required state-owned oil companies to maintain gasoline and diesel inventories at pre-war levels to qualify for export quotas. Yet the NDRC often waits until the last minute to confirm allocations, and export limits were reinstated in September. China has thus become

an unreliable regional supplier. A blanket export ban is unlikely, as Beijing would be reluctant to disrupt supplies to key trading partners such as Southeast Asian countries and Australia or create another source of friction with the US. The Huajin-Aramco refinery in Liaoning may begin operations in late 2026 or early 2027, which could ease supply constraints and reduce the need for export restrictions.

Dan Wang
Director, China
+65 90964887
wang@eurasiagroup.net
Henning Gloystein
Managing Director, Energy & Resources
+44 (0)73 898 444 98
gloystein@eurasiagroup.net
Herbert Crowther
Senior Analyst, Energy & Resources
+1 435.625.7886
crowther@eurasiagroup.net
Xuanqiao Sun
Researcher, China
Sun@eurasiagroup.net
Gerard DiPippo
Director, Global Macro
dipippo@eurasiagroup.net
EG China
china@eurasiagroup.net
EG Energy, Climate & Resources
ecr@eurasiagroup.net

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